

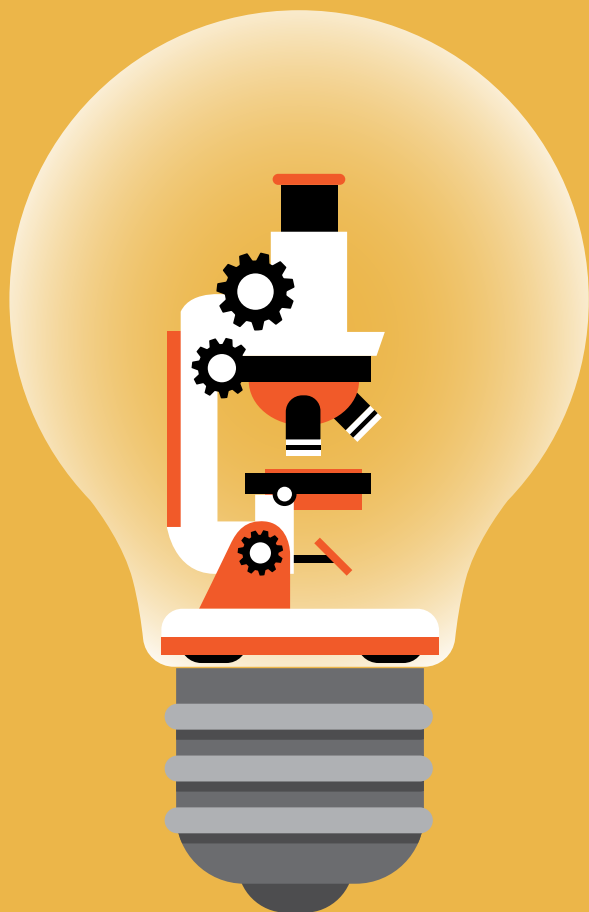


ILLUSTRATION BY TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

learning from failures; it's an iterative process.

FAIL FAST, LEARN FROM MISTAKES

Once you have embarked on a journey to innovate, you are bound to take false steps. The sooner you fail, and more often you do, the closer you get to a breakthrough. Sometimes, failures are also stepping stones. At Zoho, we have built certain products that did not do well in the market or became obsolete. However, the base technology became the foundation for other

products that went on to compete with global giants.

PEOPLE ARE THE REAL CAPITAL

Your employees who will spend years and years mastering a particular field—they are your most important asset. You cannot replace or outsource that expertise, as some international companies are learning now. You can never outspend your competitors, and so the only way to keep your employees close is through culture and shared vision.

These cannot be afterthoughts, they need to be foundational to building your company.

THE TALENT TRAP

The reality that we can attest to is that talent is everywhere. In fact, most of the talent in the metros comes from smaller towns. Building your business where the talent is also reduces operational costs, providing you a longer runway. We are already witnessing a shift of start-ups to Tier II/III cities, and it's now time to tap the rural talent that is hungry for a chance to prove themselves. You will have to nurture the talent, but this is a worthwhile investment.

KEEP AN EAR TO THE GROUND

It's important to stay in close touch with your existing or potential customers, keeping pace with their evolving needs, incorporating their feedback, and ensuring you are headed in the right direction. It's also a good idea to have a road map to serve diverse markets, spreading out, and not be dependent on just one source of income.

There will still be times when you do everything right, and yet your product may fail; or, a technological breakthrough may render your efforts pointless. Back in 2000, the dot-com bust wiped out over 90% of our clients. As a small company, what else could we do but be nimble and pivot? We used our savings to invest in building IT management solutions, and later, entered the cloud market.

Building an R&D-led company is not easy, but this is certainly the way to create a lasting brand that will make a global impact. **BT**

Views are personal